

Q How can we deal with my pregnancy loss and look forward to the future again?

After the devastating loss of your pregnancy, giving yourselves time to grieve can help you process what has happened and to start to look to the future. You may feel a range of emotions during this time. Finding coping strategies and seeking support can help the healing process.

There are many emotions associated with grieving, and you may feel some, or all, of these at different times. It's common to feel numb at first, and this is your body's way of dealing with the shock of the loss of your pregnancy. In time, feeling numb will pass and you may feel angry, cheated, or resentful. When those feelings also pass, you may feel deeply sad, withdrawn, or even depressed—not wanting to see friends or family, crying uncontrollably, or retreating into yourself. All these responses are perfectly normal and are symptoms of your intensely personal response to your loss. Eventually, though, you will emerge adjusted for life without your baby. Although “getting over it” isn't the right term—you will always remember your loss—you will be able to accept what has happened, and to start to move forward. There are a range of things you can do, and steps you can take, to help you to deal with your loss, and throughout your grief, the most important thing you can do is to express how you're feeling—through words and actions.

» **Try writing a letter to your baby** Tell her how loved she was, and what you had hoped for her. Fold the letter and put it in an envelope and keep it somewhere safe.

» **Keep a daily journal of your feelings** Putting your thoughts down on paper can help to formalize and organize them, which can help you feel more in control of them, if this is what you need.

» **Talk it through with your partner** You may not feel like doing this at first, but when you're both ready, don't shut each other out. Remember that just as you intend to parent together, you have both experienced the loss together. Try to give each other room to express your grief in your own ways, and support and comfort each other, too.

» Have a ceremony to remember your baby

You might want to plant a tree in your yard or dedicate a bench in your local park so that you have somewhere to go to remember and reflect on the baby you lost.

» **Join a miscarriage support group** This way you can meet other couples who have experienced what you're going through. Sharing how you feel with those who truly understand provides a unique network of comfort and understanding that can reassure you that you're not alone.

While everyone deals with loss in their own way, how you respond to your miscarriage can often depend on your individual circumstances, and may be influenced by the course your miscarriage took. For example, if you had a lot of pain and bleeding, it may take longer for you to feel physically recovered. If the miscarriage played out over a relatively long period of time, you may feel particularly exhausted, though you may also feel a sense of relief that the miscarriage is behind you. Allowing yourself time to recover and to process your emotions is likely to help

Support each other Facing the loss of your pregnancy together can help you both to cope with the difficult emotions that miscarriage brings up.

you move on more completely. If, though, after a period of time you are finding it hard to shift your emotions, or you still feel below par physically, talk to your doctor, who can review your recovery and may have suggestions to help you to cope. Getting the right help and support can help you to avoid feeling isolated with your loss and give you the strength and resilience you need to look forward to the future again.

